

SOCIAL STRESS

- 'Stress' is used in countless ways
- "A state of imbalance within a person, elicited by an actual or perceived disparity between environmental demands and the person's capacity to cope with these demands."
- Walter Cannon and the concept of homeostasis... physiological (adaptive) changes

The stressors

Homeostasis is the body's natural ability to maintain a stable and balanced internal environment despite external changes.

- A primary concern of sociologists was to identify the social factors
- A key insight of sociology is that all human behavior, even that which seems to be very individualistic, is shaped by larger forces in the social environment.
- French sociologist Emile Durkheim (1858–1917)





- If suicide is an entirely personal, individual behavior, why do rates of suicide vary from social group to social group?
- The extent and nature to which individuals were integrated into a group or society
- On this basis, suicide is more likely to occur if:
 - Insufficient integration and fewer social bonds
 - Enough integrated and identifies with a social group to even sacrifice life
 - Feeling of normless during rapid socio-economic changes... e.g. culture of mobile phone (constant accessibility, compression of time and space)...processed vs. lived, recorded vs. remembered and tracked vs. understood...trying to keep up makes it difficult not to exceed optimal level of stimulation



Types of stressors

Life events: (specific events which interrupts... requires adjustment)

- Anticipated/scheduled
- Unanticipated/unscheduled
- Effects of these are understood in three techniques:
 - Studies of the psychiatric effects of specific events
 - Number and types of life events experienced by psychiatric patients
 - General population surveys examining the relationship between life events, stress, and illness

Chronic strains: relatively enduring problems, conflicts, and threats that people typically face in their daily lives

- Role of the boundaries of major social roles and role sets... relationship is enduring and needs ultimate attention



The role strain: hardships experienced while engaged in social role (five types)

▣ ***Role overload:***

- Common for all sections of work and people
- Economic return on one's labor

▣ ***Interpersonal conflicts within role sets***

▣ ***Interrole conflict:*** when the demands of two or more roles held by a person are incompatible, and the demands cannot simultaneously be met.

▣ ***Role captivity:*** situations in which an individual is in an unwanted role

▣ ***Role restructuring:*** where long-established patterns or expectations undergo considerable restructuring



Three final points about chronic strain

- Chronic strains are a more powerful determinant of depressive disorders and other health problems than are discrete life events
- Valid and reliable measurement of chronic strains (like life events) is complicated
- Life events and chronic strains may accumulate over time and often overlap

Symbolic interactionism:

- It believe that social life is comprised of a myriad number of episodes of daily **social interactions** in which people communicate **verbally and nonverbally** and engage in a constant process of **interpreting** others' messages and **responding** to these interpretations
- Individuals are affected by events only to the extent to which they are perceived



- It believe that social life is comprised of a myriad number of episodes of daily **social interactions** in which people communicate **verbally and nonverbally** and engage in a constant process of **interpreting** others' messages and **responding** to these interpretations
- Individuals are affected by events only to the extent to which they are perceived
- Life events and chronic strains are just situations...our response is based on our perception of these
- What an individual believes the implications of the events/strains to be—that is stressful

The Appraisal Process

- In stress situations we evaluate or appraise its significance for us...going back to past or remember if we read...asking self
- The same stressful circumstances do not lead to the same stress outcomes in all people...role of mediators

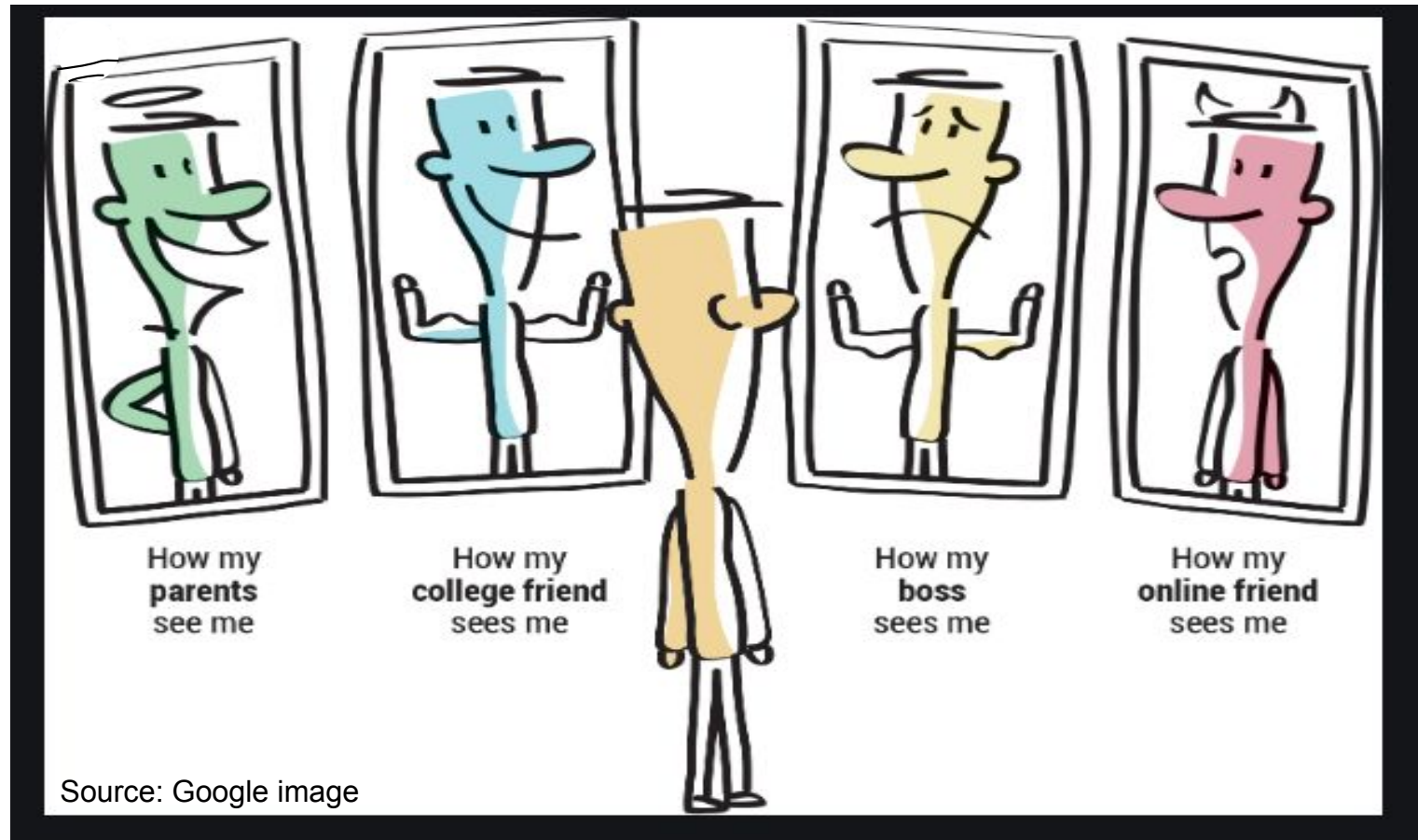
Mediators of stress and Sociological Perspective

- A classic illustration of the way the social environment influences our self-image (and, thus, our feelings of confidence in dealing with social stress) is **Charles Horton Cooley's** (1864–1929) theory of the **looking-glass self**



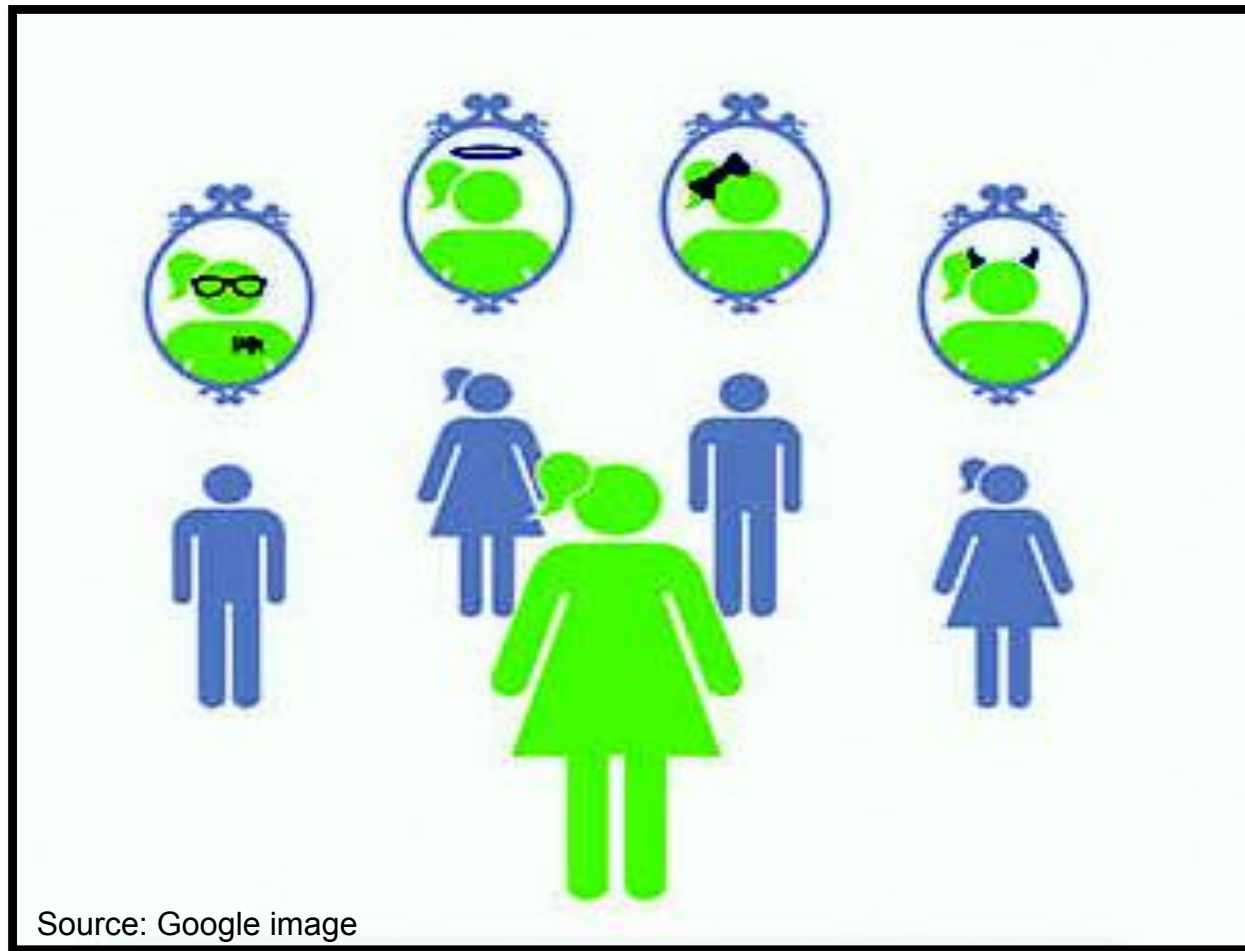
❖ This theory has **three principal elements/assumptions**:

1. The imagination of our appearance to other persons



❖ We perceive in **another's mind some thought of our own appearance**, manners, aims, character and so on

2. The imagination of their judgment of our appearance



- ❖ Imagination of **being judged**/evaluated as being humorous, clever, wise or evil

3. Response towards this judgment (self-feelings)



- ❖ Self-identification results in **development of our feelings**—be it joy or grief



Coping:

- It is personal responses people make to prevent, avoid, or control emotional distress and includes efforts to:
 - eliminate or modify the stressful **situation**
 - control the **meaning** of the problem
 - control the **stress** created by the situation

Specific Coping Techniques.

There are three types of coping techniques:

- Psychological resources
- Cognitive techniques
- Behavioral techniques



Psychological resources

- Psychological resources are the personality characteristics
 - Individuals with positive feelings about 'self'
 - Individuals with a feeling of being in control (internal vs. external control)
 - Individuals characterized by a trait referred to as hardiness (strong commitment)
- Cognitive techniques involve the assignment of specific interpretations to a stressful event in order to control its meaning (i.e., to neutralize its stressfulness)... sometimes being spiritual
- Behavioral techniques...how we deal with situations through activities